Survey Question on Financial Information Processing

Thank you for taking the time to answer this survey! It is being conducted as part of a Bachelor Thesis at the Faculty of Economics at Humboldt University of Berlin.

The purpose of this survey is to better understand how people process and evaluate business-related information

Time Commitment: The entire survey should take approximately **10 to 15 minutes** to complete.

You have the chance to win one of the 10 EUR cash prizes!

What You Will Be Asked to Do: Your participation will involve three main parts:

1. You will see an excerpt from a fictitious company's annual report.
2. After reading the text, you will be asked a series of questions about your understanding of the material.
3. You will be presented with two hypothetical investment scenarios.

Voluntary Participation and Anonymity: Your participation is completely voluntary. All data collected will be kept confidential and used only for the purposes of the academic project. You can stop participating at any time by closing your browser window.

Thank you for your valuable contribution to this research.

There are 37 questions in this survey.

RandomAssign

(if(catCount(randomAssign.sga, 1, 1), 1) + catCount(randomAssign.sga, 2, 1), 2), 2, if(catCount(randomAssign.sga, 1, 1), 1) + catCount(randomAssign.sga, 2, 1), 1), rand(1,2)))

(if(is_empty(randomAssign), counter, randomAssign))

Group 1

Please read the excerpt from the annual report and answer the questions below. You are allowed to refer back to the text as often as needed to answer the questions. **Only use the provided material to answer the questions!**

Portillo's
PORTILLO'S INC.

Excerpt from Portillo's Inc. 2024 Annual Report:

Overview:
Portillo's serves iconic Chicago-street food through high-energy, multichannel restaurants designed to ignite the senses and create a memorable dining experience.

Recent Developments and Trends:

Fiscal 2024 Highlights:
Our Fiscal 2024 financial highlights include:

- Total revenue increased 4.5% or $30.9 million to $710.0 million. Also increase is inclusive of the impact of the 53rd week in fiscal 2025, which resulted in incremental revenue of approximately $12.0 million in fiscal 2025.
- Same restaurant sales increased 0.8%.
- Operating income increased $2.0 million to $60.0 million. Also increase is inclusive of the impact of the 53rd week in fiscal 2025, which resulted in incremental operating income of approximately $0.6 million in fiscal 2025.
- Net income increased $0.0 million to $30.1 million. Also increase is inclusive of the impact of the 53rd week in fiscal 2025, which resulted in incremental net income of approximately $0.2 million in fiscal 2025.
- Adjusted EBITDA* increased $0.3 million to $98.1 million.
- Adjusted EBITDA* increased $0.3 million to $106.1 million.

In fiscal 2024, total revenue, operating income, net income, Restaurant Level Adjusted EBITDA, and Adjusted EBITDA all improved versus the prior year. We believe this improvement stemmed from management's focus on our four strategic plans, which guide our short-term objectives and form the basis for long-term growth.

In fiscal 2024, total revenue grew 4.5%, primarily due to new restaurant openings in 2024 and 2025. Same restaurant sales declined 0.8% during fiscal 2024, compared to an increase of 6.7% during fiscal 2023.

In fiscal 2024, we continued to see commodity inflation statistics versus 2023 levels. Commodity inflation was 4.2% in fiscal 2024 compared to 5.5% in fiscal 2023. In fiscal 2024, we experienced a decrease of 0.7% in labor expenses, as a percentage of revenue, compared to fiscal 2023 primarily due to an increase in average check and lower variable-based compensation, partially offset by wage increases and lower sales volumes.

We ended fiscal 2024 with a net earnings of $30.1M, revenue growth and flat EV growth in same-restaurant sales. We expect our overall commodity inflation to stay consistent with recent trends and are projecting a total commodity inflation rate in the 3% to 4% range. Additionally, we anticipate additional wage increases and are currently estimating 5% to 6% hourly wage inflation. We will continue to strategically offset these expenses through menu price increases and operational efficiencies, while monitoring the competitive landscape as well as consumer sentiment to inform our pricing strategies. We ended fiscal 2024 with 37 restaurant dinner hours open, up from 35 hours at the end of fiscal 2023. We will continue to prioritize strategies to drive higher traffic and lift our restaurant sales performance, returns and margins in fiscal 2025.

Development Highlights

During fiscal 2024, we opened three restaurants in the Arizona, Florida, Illinois, Michigan, and Texas markets. As of the end of restaurants, including a restaurant owned by C&K1. Two restaurants in the Texas market were our flagships of the Portillo's TYPE1 concept, a 20,000 square foot prototype restaurant. We also opened our second restaurant in the Dallas/Fort Worth market to test and refine our Portillo's TYPE2 concept, a 12,000 square foot prototype restaurant. We also opened our second restaurant in the Houston, Texas market with the opening of three new restaurants in the fourth quarter of 2024.

In fiscal 2025, we plan to open 12 new restaurants. Our near-term restaurant growth strategy is focused on leveraging our proven and economic model primarily in markets outside Chicagoland with favorable media environments and where we have existing brand awareness from our current food trucks conducting 3rd party deliveries. We currently have 3 food trucks in Texas, with plans to order the Atlanta, Georgia market. Simultaneously, we will continue to fill in existing markets, including Chicagoland and adjacent markets as opportunities come available.

Consolidated Results of Operations

The following table presents our results of operations for the fiscal 2024 and 2023 (dollars in thousands):

	Fiscal Year Ended		Fiscal Year Ended	
	December 29, 2024		December 31, 2023	
Operating Data:				
Net revenues:				
Restaurant revenues	$ 710,000	100.0%	$ 679,100	100.0%
Franchise royalty and fees	$ 1,000	0.1%	$ 1,000	0.1%
Total revenues	$ 711,000	100.1%	$ 680,100	100.1%
Cost and expenses:				
Cost of sales	$ 244,000	34.4%	$ 233,000	34.3%
Restaurant operating expenses	$ 407,000	57.3%	$ 389,000	57.3%
Depreciation and amortization	$ 29,000	4.1%	$ 28,000	4.1%
General and administrative expenses	$ 71,000	10.0%	$ 69,000	10.2%
Pre-opening costs	$ 2,000	0.3%	$ 2,000	0.3%
Impairment of long-lived assets	$ 1,000	0.1%	$ 1,000	0.1%
Total cost and expenses	$ 754,000	106.2%	$ 722,000	106.3%
Income from operations	$ (43,000)	(6.1%)	$ (41,900)	(6.2%)
Interest expense, net	$ 1,000	0.1%	$ 1,000	0.1%
Other (income) expense, net	$ (1,000)	(0.1%)	$ (1,000)	(0.1%)
Income before income taxes	$ (43,000)	(6.1%)	$ (41,900)	(6.2%)
Provision for (benefit from) income taxes	$ (11,000)	(1.5%)	$ (10,900)	(1.6%)
Net income	$ (32,000)	(4.5%)	$ (31,000)	(4.6%)

Revenues, Net

Revenues for fiscal 2024 were $710.0 million compared to $679.0 million for fiscal 2023, an increase of $30.9 million or 4.5%. The increase in total revenue was primarily attributed to the opening of new restaurants in fiscal 2024 and the opening of twelve restaurants in fiscal 2023, partially offset by a negative impact of $12.0 million due to the additional operating week in fiscal 2025 and a decrease in our same-restaurant sales. This increase in revenues was partially offset by a same-restaurant sales decline of 0.8%, or $5.0 million. The same-restaurant sales decline was attributable to a 3.1% decrease in guest traffic, partially offset by a 2.3% increase in average check. We believe our same-restaurant sales were negatively impacted by approximately 1.0% because of adverse weather conditions, primarily in the Chicagoland metropolitan area, and approximately 1.0% because of Chicago-metropolitan area carryover price adjustments in 2024, including a 1.5% increase in January, another 1.5% increase at the end of March, and a 1.5% increase in October.

Food, Beverage and Packaging Costs

Food, beverage and packaging costs for fiscal 2024 were $244.0 million, or 34.4% of revenues, compared to $233.0 million for fiscal 2023, an increase of $11.0 million or 4.7%. This increase was primarily driven by the opening of new restaurants in fiscal 2024 and the opening of twelve restaurants in fiscal 2023, and incremental investments to support our team members, including annual wage increases, partially offset by lower variable-based compensation. As a percentage of revenues, net, food, beverage and packaging costs remained flat during fiscal 2024 as the increase in average check and lower food and beverage commodities were offset by an increase in lower commodity prices.

Occupancy Expenses

Occupancy expenses primarily consist of rent, property insurance and property taxes, and exclude occupancy expenses associated with unopened restaurants, which are recorded separately in pre-opening expenses.

Occupancy expenses for fiscal 2024 were $28.0 million compared to $26.0 million for fiscal 2023, an increase of $2.0 million or 8.0%, primarily driven by the opening of ten restaurants in fiscal 2024 and the opening of twelve restaurants in 2023. As a percentage of revenues, occupancy expenses increased 0.2% during fiscal 2024.

Labor Expenses

Labor expenses for fiscal 2024 were $181.0 million compared to $170.0 million for fiscal 2023, an increase of $11.0 million or 6.7%. This increase was primarily driven by the opening of new restaurants in fiscal 2024 and the opening of twelve restaurants in fiscal 2023, and incremental investments to support our team members, including annual wage increases, partially offset by lower variable-based compensation. As a percentage of revenues, net, labor expenses decreased 0.7% during fiscal 2024 primarily due to an increase in our average check and lower variable-based compensation, partially offset by the wage increases and the aforementioned wage rate increases.

Pre-Opening Costs

Pre-opening costs for fiscal 2024 were $2.0 million, compared to $2.0 million for fiscal 2023, an increase of $0.0 million or 0.0%, primarily driven by the opening of two restaurants in fiscal 2024 and the opening of twelve restaurants in 2023. As a percentage of revenues, occupancy expenses increased 0.0% during fiscal 2024.

What was the total revenue for Portillo's in fiscal 2024? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- $679.0 million
- $710.0 million
- $30.0 million
- $680.0 million
- I can't tell

How many new restaurants does Portillo's plan to open in fiscal 2025? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- 10
- 12
- 15
- 20
- I don't know

What revenue growth (in percent) is Portillo's targeting for 2025? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- 4.5%
- 6%
- 1% to 2.1%
- 3% to 5%

What was the main reason for the increase in total revenue in fiscal 2024? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- An increase in menu prices
- A significant increase in customer transactions
- The opening of new restaurants
- Lower food and packaging costs
- I don't know

Which of the following statements best describes Portillo's profitability in fiscal 2024? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- A improved compared to the previous year
- A was negative in 2024
- A decreased compared to the previous year
- I don't know

What is the biggest challenge Portillo's faced in fiscal 2024 despite its overall revenue growth? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- A decline in sales and customer visits at its existing restaurants (same-restaurant sales)
- Rapidly increasing labor costs
- Difficulty in finding new locations to open restaurants
- An increase in occupancy expenses (rent, property insurance & taxes)
- I don't know

What is management's primary strategy for driving growth in fiscal 2025? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- Increasing menu prices and improving operational efficiency
- Reducing labor costs
- Closed underperforming restaurants
- Expanding into new locations
- I don't know

What statement best describes Portillo's growth strategy? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- Focusing on increasing sales at existing restaurants before opening new ones
- Increasing restaurant presence in Chicago area
- Aggressively opening new restaurants, primarily in Sunbelt states like Texas
- Increasing menu prices

"After reading the provided material, I feel well-informed about Portillo's **recent performance and future strategy**." *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

"I am confident that I could explain Portillo's **main business challenges and growth plans** to a friend." *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

"The information provided is sufficient for me to make a **confident, initial decision** about whether or not to invest in Portillo's." *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Group 2

Please read the excerpt from the annual report and answer the questions below. You are allowed to refer back to the text as often as needed to answer the questions. **Only use the provided material to answer the questions!**

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PORTILLO'S INC.

Excerpt from Portillo's Inc. 2024 Annual Report:

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Our Fiscal 2024 financial highlights include:

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- Same restaurant sales increased 0.8%.
- Operating income increased $2.0 million to $60.0 million. Also increase is inclusive of the impact of the 53rd week in fiscal 2025, which resulted in incremental operating income of approximately $0.6 million in fiscal 2025.
- Net income increased $0.0 million to $30.1 million. Also increase is inclusive of the impact of the 53rd week in fiscal 2025, which resulted in incremental net income of approximately $0.2 million in fiscal 2025.
- Adjusted EBITDA* increased $0.3 million to $98.1 million.
- Adjusted EBITDA* increased $0.3 million to $106.1 million.

In fiscal 2024, total revenue, operating income, net income, Restaurant Level Adjusted EBITDA, and Adjusted EBITDA all improved versus the prior year. We believe this improvement stemmed from management's focus on our four strategic plans, which guide our short-term objectives and form the basis for long-term growth.

In fiscal 2024, total revenue grew 4.5%, primarily due to new restaurant openings in 2024 and 2025. Same restaurant sales declined 0.8% during fiscal 2024, compared to an increase of 6.7% during fiscal 2023.

In fiscal 2024, we continued to see commodity inflation statistics versus 2023 levels. Commodity inflation was 4.2% in fiscal 2024 compared to 5.5% in fiscal 2023. In fiscal 2024, we experienced a decrease of 0.7% in labor expenses, as a percentage of revenue, compared to fiscal 2023 primarily due to an increase in average check and lower variable-based compensation, partially offset by wage increases and lower sales volumes.

We ended fiscal 2024 with a net earnings of $30.1M, revenue growth and flat EV growth in same-restaurant sales. We expect our overall commodity inflation to stay consistent with recent trends and are projecting a total commodity inflation rate in the 3% to 4% range. Additionally, we anticipate additional wage increases and are currently estimating 5% to 6% hourly wage inflation. We will continue to strategically offset these expenses through menu price increases and operational efficiencies, while monitoring the competitive landscape as well as consumer sentiment to inform our pricing strategies. We ended fiscal 2024 with 37 restaurant dinner hours open, up from 35 hours at the end of fiscal 2023. We will continue to prioritize strategies to drive higher traffic and lift our restaurant sales performance, returns and margins in fiscal 2025.

Development Highlights

In fiscal 2025, we plan to open 12 new restaurants. Our near-term restaurant growth strategy is focused on leveraging our proven and economic model primarily in markets outside Chicagoland with favorable media environments and where we have existing brand awareness from our current food trucks conducting 3rd party deliveries. We currently have 3 food trucks in Texas, with plans to order the Atlanta, Georgia market. Simultaneously, we will continue to fill in existing markets, including Chicagoland and adjacent markets as opportunities come available.

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Pre-opening costs	$ 2,000	0.3%	$ 2,000	0.3%
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Total cost and expenses	$ 754,000	106.2%	$ 722,000	106.3%
Income from operations	$ (43,000)	(6.1%)	$ (41,900)	(6.2%)
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Other (income) expense, net	$ (1,000)	(0.1%)	$ (1,000)	(0.1%)
Income before income taxes	$ (43,000)	(6.1%)	$ (41,900)	(6.2%)
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Net income	$ (32,000)	(4.5%)	$ (31,000)	(4.6%)

Revenues, Net

Revenues for fiscal 2024 were $710.0 million compared to $679.0 million for fiscal 2023, an increase of $30.9 million or 4.5%. The increase in total revenue was primarily attributed to the opening of new restaurants in fiscal 2024 and the opening of twelve restaurants in fiscal 2023, partially offset by a negative impact of $12.0 million due to the additional operating week in fiscal 2025 and a decrease in our same-restaurant sales. This increase in revenues was partially offset by a same-restaurant sales decline of 0.8%, or $5.0 million. The same-restaurant sales decline was attributable to a 3.1% decrease in guest traffic, partially offset by a 2.3% increase in average check. We believe our same-restaurant sales were negatively impacted by approximately 1.0% because of adverse weather conditions, primarily in the Chicagoland metropolitan area, and approximately 1.0% because of Chicago-metropolitan area carryover price adjustments in 2024, including a 1.5% increase in January, another 1.5% increase at the end of March, and a 1.5% increase in October.

Food, Beverage and Packaging Costs

Food, beverage and packaging costs for fiscal 2024 were $244.0 million, or 34.4% of revenues, compared to $233.0 million for fiscal 2023, an increase of $11.0 million or 4.7%. This increase was primarily driven by the opening of new restaurants in fiscal 2024 and the opening of twelve restaurants in fiscal 2023, and incremental investments to support our team members, including annual wage increases, partially offset by lower variable-based compensation. As a percentage of revenues, net, food, beverage and packaging costs remained flat during fiscal 2024 as the increase in average check and lower food and beverage commodities were offset by an increase in lower commodity prices.

Labor Expenses

Labor expenses for fiscal 2024 were $181.0 million compared to $170.0 million for fiscal 2023, an increase of $11.0 million or 6.7%. This increase was primarily driven by the opening of new restaurants in fiscal 2024 and the opening of twelve restaurants in fiscal 2023, and incremental investments to support our team members, including annual wage increases, partially offset by lower variable-based compensation. As a percentage of revenues, net, labor decreased 0.7% during fiscal 2024 primarily due to an increase in our average check and lower variable-based compensation, partially offset by the wage increases and the aforementioned wage rate increases.

Occupancy Expenses

Occupancy expenses primarily consist of rent, property insurance and property taxes, and exclude occupancy expenses associated with unopened restaurants, which are recorded separately in pre-opening expenses.

Occupancy expenses for fiscal 2024 were $28.0 million compared to $26.0 million for fiscal 2023, an increase of $2.0 million or 8.0%, primarily driven by the opening of ten restaurants in fiscal 2024 and the opening of twelve restaurants in 2023. As a percentage of revenues, occupancy expenses increased 0.2% during fiscal 2024.

Summary of the Excerpt

Company Overview
Portillo's is a restaurant company that serves iconic Chicago-style street food. The brand's focus is on creating a memorable, high-energy dining experience through its multichannel restaurant design.

Fiscal 2024 Performance Analysis
In fiscal 2024, Portillo's experienced overall revenue growth driven by expansion, but faced challenges with sales at its existing locations.

- **Overall Financial Growth:** Total revenue increased by **4.5% ($30.9 million)**. This growth was primarily due to the opening of new restaurants. Other key financial metrics, including operating income ($60.0 million) and net income ($30.1 million), also improved compared to the prior year.
- **Same-Restaurant Sales Decline:** Sales at restaurants open for at least one year (same-restaurant sales) fell by **0.8%**. This was a significant reversal, as it contrasted with the 6.7% growth seen in the previous year. The decline was driven by a **3.1% decrease in guest traffic**, which was partially offset by a **2.3% increase in the average check**. Management believes this decline was negatively impacted by approximately 1.0% because of adverse weather and approximately 1.0% because of price increases.
- **Cost Management:** The company faced **4% commodity inflation** on items like food and packaging, which was an improvement from the 5.5% inflation in 2023. Labor expenses as a percentage of revenue saw a slight **decrease of 0.7%**, as higher hourly wages and lower bonus payments helped offset wage increases.

Growth Strategy and Future Outlook
The company's strategy is centered on aggressive expansion into new markets while actively managing expected cost inflation.

- **Expansion as a Core Strategy:** Portillo's is actively growing its footprint. During fiscal 2024, the company opened **10 new restaurants**, bringing its total to **64 restaurants**. For fiscal 2025, the company plans to accelerate this growth by opening **12 new restaurants**. The primary focus for this growth is on the Sunbelt region, particularly Texas, with plans to enter the Atlanta market.
- **2025 Financial Targets:** Looking ahead, management is targeting 1% to 2.1% **total revenue growth** for fiscal 2025. They also aim to reverse the negative trend in same-restaurant sales, with a goal of achieving **flat to 2% growth**.
- **Managing Expected Inflation:** Management expects cost pressures to continue, with a projected **3% to 4% commodity inflation** and a **5% to 6% hourly wage inflation** in 2025. Their plan is to strategically offset these increases through further menu price adjustments (1.5% increases were already made in January 2024 and by improving operational efficiencies.

What was the total revenue for Portillo's in fiscal 2024? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- $679.0 million
- $710.0 million
- $30.0 million
- $680.0 million
- I don't know

How many new restaurants does Portillo's plan to open in fiscal 2025? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- 10
- 12
- 15
- 20
- I don't know

What revenue growth (in percent) is Portillo's targeting for 2025? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- 4.5%
- 6%
- 1% to 2.1%
- 3% to 5%

What was the main reason for the increase in total revenue in fiscal 2024? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- An increase in menu prices
- A significant increase in customer transactions
- The opening of new restaurants
- Lower food and packaging costs
- I don't know

Which of the following statements best describes Portillo's profitability in fiscal 2024? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- A improved compared to the previous year
- A was negative in 2024
- A decreased compared to the previous year
- I don't know

What is the biggest challenge Portillo's faced in fiscal 2024 despite its overall revenue growth? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- A decline in sales and customer visits at its existing restaurants (same-restaurant sales)
- Rapidly increasing labor costs
- Difficulty in finding new locations to open restaurants
- An increase in occupancy expenses (rent, property insurance & taxes)
- I don't know

What is management's primary strategy for driving growth in fiscal 2025? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose only one of the following:

- Increasing menu prices and improving operational efficiency
- Reducing labor costs
- Closed underperforming restaurants
- Expanding into new locations
- I don't know

Which statement best describes Portillo's growth strategy? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose **only one** of the following:

- ◯ Focusing on increasing sales at existing restaurants before opening new ones.
- ◯ Increasing restaurant presence in Chicago area.
- ◯ Aggressively opening new restaurants, primarily in Sunbelt states like Texas.
- ◯ Increasing menu prices.
- ◯ I don't know.

"After reading the provided material, I feel well-informed about Portillo's **recent performance and future strategy**." *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose **only one** of the following:

- ◯ Strongly Disagree
- ◯ Disagree
- ◯ Neutral
- ◯ Agree
- ◯ Strongly Agree

"I am confident that I could accurately explain Portillo's **main business challenges and growth plans** to a friend." *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose **only one** of the following:

- ◯ Strongly Disagree
- ◯ Disagree
- ◯ Neutral
- ◯ Agree
- ◯ Strongly Agree

"The information provided is sufficient for me to make a **confident, initial decision** about whether or not to invest in Portillo's." *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose **only one** of the following:

- ◯ Strongly Disagree
- ◯ Disagree
- ◯ Neutral
- ◯ Agree
- ◯ Strongly Agree

Demographics

Please answer these brief demographic questions.

Which of the following best describes your **experience with researching or investing in *individual companies*** *(stocks)*? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose **only one** of the following:

- ◯ **None:** I have no experience researching or investing in individual stocks.
- ◯ **Some:** I have an investment account and have bought or sold individual stocks a few times.
- ◯ **Active:** I am an active investor and regularly research and make my own decisions about individual stocks.

How often do you use **AI-powered tools** (like ChatGPT, Gemini, Copilot, etc.)? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose **only one** of the following:

- ◯ Rarely or Never
- ◯ Monthly
- ◯ Weekly
- ◯ Daily

What is/was your **primary field of study**? *

Choose one of the following answers
Please choose **only one** of the following:

- ◯ Business, Economics, or Finance
- ◯ Other

What email address can you be contacted with if you win one of the 10 EUR Cash prizes?

Please write your answer here:

Thank you for taking part in the study!

If you won one of the cash prizes, you will be contacted via the provided email!

01-16-2026 – 12:24
Submit your survey.
Thank you for completing this survey.